

firm. "Freezing my eggs made me feel like I could focus on work without feeling the clock ticking." Her sentiment is shared by others. "This narrative of 'career versus family' never fit me," says Rhea Mathew, 34, who works in finance and froze embryos with her partner last year. "I want children. Just not when I am drowning in 14-hour workdays."

Doctors confirm that the primary driver is not fear, but timing. "Many young women I meet today are not saying they don't want children. Rather, they want to plan their pregnancy at the right time. Egg freezing helps them focus on studies, career or personal goals without feeling rushed or stressed about their biological clock," says Dr Archana Dhawan Bajaj, Gynaecologist and IVF Expert at Nurture Clinic, an IVF clinic based in New Delhi.

BOOST IN BUSINESS

The convergence between changing social norms and rising financial independence has created a fertile business landscape for clinics. Fertility specialists describe a marked shift in those seeking consultations. "Earlier, only a few women would ask about egg freezing. Now, every week, more and more walk in just to understand how it works. Most of them are in their late twenties or early thirties. They want to make informed choices, and that is a very positive change," says Dr Bajaj.

This growth can be marked in numbers. According to IMARC Group, in 2024, the overall IVF market in India was valued at \$865 million. According to estimates by Grand View Research, the elective egg-freezing and embryo-banking segment was pegged at \$206 million in 2023. To meet rising demand, clinics are investing in new laboratory technology, improved freezing protocols and large-capacity biobanks.

"Egg freezing is increasingly being recognised as a vital component of reproductive planning in India," says Dr Kshitiz Murdia, CEO and Whole-Time Director of Indira IVF Hospital Ltd. Two decades ago, the procedure was mostly restricted to women undergoing chemotherapy or facing urgent medical risks, he says.

Today, clinics see a more diverse group. "Women are delaying motherhood for education, career advance-

ment, financial stability or personal reasons," says Dr Murdia. "Changing social attitudes have encouraged more women to preserve fertility in line with their life goals."

Affordability, however, remains a hurdle. "A single cycle typically costs between ₹1.2 lakh and ₹2.5 lakh, while annual storage fees can reach ₹60,000. It is a significant financial commitment," he says. While a handful of companies now offer insurance cover or subsidies, "the majority of women continue to bear these expenses independently," he adds.

AMBITION AND FAMILY

Doctors infer that women often carry the weight of feeling they must achieve stability on all fronts. "Freezing gives you the flexibility to plan for the future," says Dr Preethi Reddy, Consultant, Infertility, Fertility By BirthRight—a fertility centre by Rainbow Hospitals. The procedure's success also depends on age, health, and the number of eggs retrieved.

Doctors emphasise the limits. "As age advances, genetic problems in eggs increase and the egg reserves in the ovary decrease," says Dr Sunita Arora, Head of the Fertility Unit at Fortis La Femme Hospital, New Delhi. The decline, she notes, is far sharper than most expect. "After thirty-six to thirty-seven years, there starts a drastic fall in egg reserve. At forty-two years, there is only 5-8% chance of conceiving with one's own eggs."

Genetic risks rise parallelly. "At 30 years, one in around 900 pregnancies get affected with Down syndrome, whereas at 35 years, this figure goes to one in 365. At 40 years it becomes one in 100, and after 40 years even more,"

she says. In this context, Dr Arora urges women who are delaying motherhood to consider fertility preservation. For married women, she highlights the alternative of social fertility preservation or social egg preservation.

Egg freezing expands choices. However, it cannot remove the challenges women face in balancing career and motherhood. That is a real challenge that will require systemic change, not just medical innovation. **BT**

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How To Do It

- 1 **Women can preserve fertility through egg or embryo freezing, known as social fertility preservation**
- 2 **Elective egg freezing is rising fast among career-focused women in India's metro cities**
- 3 **Fertility drops sharply after 36, with only a 5-8% chance of conceiving with one's own eggs at 42**
- 4 **Egg freezing costs ₹1.2-2.5 lakh per cycle, plus up to ₹60,000 a year for storage**
- 5 **Genetic risks rises with age, with Down Syndrome risk rising from 1 in 900 at 30 to 1 in 100 at 40**